

On the Original Relationship between Religion and Science

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I.

The bitter conflict between religion and science cannot be resolved unless it is done on the inescapable condition that the original independence of each is mutually acknowledged. Religion by itself must then be able to subsist without any science, and science by itself without any religion; but how is that possible? That religion is not of scientific origin, “revealed religion” no more than the myths, must surely be conceded; but history teaches that science has scarcely opened its eyes before it begins to shake the given religion and to open the conflict. Among the Greeks it was above all the philosophers who led the attack. Xenophanes pointed out contradictions in the polytheistic popular faith; against the many gods he set unity, against their temporal origin eternity, against the inconstancy of their nature immutability, against their likeness to human beings sublimity, etc.¹ In the great poets one traces a gradual change in the nature of the gods; in Euripides they already begin to fall prey to reflection. A natural interpretation draws nearer to the cultivated mind. Art held fast to form, but precisely the perfection of plastic form ate away at the reality of the gods. The Zeus at Olympia no doubt stood as a mediator between the popular faith and the philosophical-critical conception; but the impression was aesthetic, and the overwhelming aesthetic impression stifled the religious. One may [2] assert without exaggeration that the scientific thinking which undermined the authority of the Greek gods had a mighty ally in plastic art.

¹Zeller, *Die Philosophie der Griechen*, 1ster Theil, 2te Auflage, Tübingen 1856. p. 381.

As regards the relation of the revealed religion of the Old and New Testaments, the matter stands differently. Endowed with rich capacities, deep feeling, magnificent imagination, sharp understanding and strong passions, the people of Israel were nevertheless not, like the Greeks, especially disposed either to plastic art or to profound scientific research; in world history they were Jehovah's people, in a distinctive sense the people of religion, the chosen people of revelation. An artistic imitation of the divine was forbidden, poetry stood exclusively in the service of religion, and critically testing science had no root in the nature of the people. That the Mosaic law, with its higher ethics, does not permit any thorough scientific investigation is evident. However much the Ten Commandments may seem to appeal to human reason, it is nevertheless immediately striking that it is not the grounds of reason but Jehovah's word on which the emphasis falls. Let it be well noted that the same God who reveals his will in the general law also speaks directly in the particular laws. Concerning the tabernacle Jehovah says (Exod. XXV): "And this is the offering which you shall take of them: gold and silver and copper; dark blue and purple and crimson and fine linen and goats' hair" etc. "And the tabernacle (XXVI) you shall make of ten curtains ... The length of each curtain shall be eight and twenty cubits and the breadth four cubits for each curtain, one measure for all the curtains" ... Let no one say that these special commandments exceed reason's power of comprehension; on the contrary, the supernatural, what is incomprehensible to us, lies in this: that the Almighty, the Creator of heaven and earth, has spoken so precisely about hangings and loops and has left nothing whatever here to Moses' common sense. It is this that must seem utterly inconceivable to reason here. In the opposite way, reason is humbled not only in the Old but also in the New Testament when the supernatural breaks through so suddenly, so mightily, that nature cracks, the bond of the laws bursts and the miracle occurs. Or does the incident of the swine of the Gadarenes perhaps not stand just as high above reason as the miracle (2 Kings XIII) of the dead man who fell down into the grave of the prophet Elisha: "life came into him, and he rose up on his feet"? In such features there appears such a rift between divine revelation and human reason that every reconciliation between religion and science must seem impossible. If revelation is to hold, then science must go; if science is to hold, then revelation must be dissolved: a desperate dilemma. [3]

We will not dwell here on particular features of the controversies which have now for almost two thousand years been conducted between faith in revelation and reason, controversies in which now religion has raised the ecclesiastical banner high and been on the point of subjugating science, now again victorious science, on behalf of offended

reason, has been about to dissolve religion; our task is to go back to the original ground of the conflict, in order to investigate whether there might not lie concealed in the ground itself a misunderstanding, an unclear commingling and confusion of religious and scientific cognition. Christ's words (John VIII, 32): "*You shall know the truth and the truth shall make you free*", rise high above all partisan disputes, and must then benefit science just as fully as religion.

But, it is objected, the truth that is to make us free must necessarily agree with itself in each and every thing. If something, seen from one side, is indeed true, but from another side untrue, then this lies not in the truth but in its presentation and apprehension. Even if all our cognition is piecemeal, the principle of cognition corresponding to truth itself cannot possibly be parceled out. Two mutually conflicting principles of cognition must surely presuppose two truths opposed in principle and in conflict with each other, but that is altogether absurd. If religious cognition stands in open conflict with scientific cognition, this cannot mean that there really are two truths here and, for cognition, two absolutely heterogeneous principles; rather, one of the two alleged principles must [4] necessarily be false, either the religious or the scientific. If the religious principle has validity, then it must comprise the whole truth, the scientific truth too; science can then lay no claim to having any principle of its own. If, conversely, it is the scientific principle that has validity, then religion is in itself without principle, and must in each and every thing be subject to the judgment of science. — We shall investigate in what follows how matters stand in this respect.

That truth in the eternal sense must be one and indivisible, everyone will surely concede; but the essence of truth is in itself two-sided, neither merely something objective nor merely something subjective, but a unity of both in cognition. Without a cognizing subject there is no cognition, and without an object that is cognized there is no cognition either. Truth itself thus can be neither the subjective by itself nor the objective by itself; the pervading unity of subjective and objective must run through the whole of existence, embracing the whole of reality with all its possibilities, in the least as in the greatest. This man, with his imperfect cognition, must concede; but in conceding it he concedes at the same time that in his limitation he cannot possibly see through the content of absolute truth in its countless forms and concretions. If man is really to cognize the truth, then the truth must divide itself; and it divides itself like light. As the light of truth streams into man's consciousness, it deposits two centers of cognition, two principles, each of which takes on its relative stamp of the Absolute, namely those of faith and of knowledge; the first concerns essentially man's own self, his inner being, and is personal; the second

concerns things and their essential connection, and is to that extent impersonal.

If faith and knowledge are separated from the corresponding principles, they will constantly flow over into each other. That faith cannot possibly do without all knowledge is just as evident as that knowledge cannot do without all faith. The believer must of course necessarily know what it is in which he believes and what it means to believe; likewise the knower must believe in his senses and his understanding. The skeptic, who can believe in neither the one nor the other, not even in his own skepticism, since the truth is that there is no truth, is shut off in equal degree from science and from religion. [5]

There is a deep-going difference between religious and scientific faith, between religious and scientific knowledge. Religious faith has a psychic-ethical stamp and is essentially a matter of conscience, a purely personal concern; scientific faith does not concern man in particular, but expresses confidence in the basic conditions and the reality of science. Religious faith sets knowledge of God and the supernatural far higher than acquaintance with the laws of reality and with natural things: all corresponding knowledge receives its significance from this alone. The supernatural cannot be sensed, and must nevertheless make itself known in an immediate way; it then takes on a sensuous-supersensuous form in imagination, and through this makes an impression on the feelings: it reveals itself. Athena revealed herself to Achilles (Il. I, 194–98), Jehovah reveals himself to Abraham, to Moses, to the prophets; even God's revelation in Christ is no exception here. In the First Epistle of John I, 1 it is indeed said: "That which was from the beginning, that which we have heard, that which we have seen with our eyes, that which we have beheld, and our hands have touched, namely concerning the Word of life"; it might well seem as though the supernatural were here directly confirmed by the senses and attested in a sensuous manner; but if we compare with this (Matt. XVI, 15–17), where Jesus says to Peter, who acknowledges him as the Son of God, "blessed are you, Simon, son of Jonas, for flesh and blood has not revealed it to you, but my Father who is in heaven", then we come to full assurance that a true knowledge of the supernatural must be of supernatural origin. The knowledge that has religious faith as its foundation cannot, then, dissolve faith; when faith wanes, the supernatural objects are instantly transformed into myths and fancies, Jehovah and Christ just as well as Zeus and Athena. In this respect Anselm, with his *credam, ut intelligam*, is undeniably right against Abelard, who wanted to reverse the relation.

It is otherwise in science. One may indeed say that scientific knowledge also begins with faith; but, for one thing, certainty about what is present to consciousness is not faith but an immediate knowledge; for another, everything that is provisionally assumed [6]

in faith, because it is assumed in untested confidence, is destined to be subjected to a testing, whereby faith, according to the Cartesian *de omnibus dubitandum est*, dissolves into doubt, and then, when the doubt has been removed by grounding, is transformed into knowledge. We begin by orienting ourselves in the world; senses, understanding and reason work together in an immediate way; now it is the senses, now the understanding, that has a one-sided preponderance, while reason nevertheless always demands that the reciprocal determination of what is sensed and what is thought be maintained, for on this scientific knowledge rests. When investigation begins concerning the difference between what is changeable in existence and what, as something unchangeable, must form the foundation of all changes, science takes its beginning. The task is to investigate the relation between things and laws. Things are sensed, laws are thought; but since things can no more exist without laws than laws can be thought without things, sensation and thinking must originally presuppose each other in the unity of reason.

That religious and scientific cognition must, according to the characterization given, be essentially different is then surely evident. Religious faith, which has its knowledge in imagination and self-feeling, casts a glance at the natural world of things, assures itself of its perishability and grasps the supernatural; weighed down by the law, it turns to the miracles and sees in them testimony that the free, almighty God is Lord of the laws. The religious laws are laws of freedom, laws of upbringing, which can be changed according to time and circumstances, such as the laws concerning clean and unclean animals; the scientific laws, mathematical, mechanical, physical-chemical etc., on the other hand belong so essentially to the nature of things that they cannot possibly be changed without nature itself having to be changed. All laws of knowledge are laws of necessity; if they could be broken or annulled, then the whole world would have to collapse; science must therefore resolutely attack the miraculous in the name of reason. [7]

There are those, no doubt, who think this too hard a saying. In actual existence there are certainly nodal points in which the supernatural and the natural, miracle and law, seem to clash with each other; but this is only apparent: the new real element introduced by the miracle must surely, by entering into connection with the natural, direct its development according to the law. Certainly, we reply, one can reconcile what is mutually contradictory in the hovering form of general propositions, but what good is that when the contradiction shows itself in the fact itself? It is related (Exod. III, 2–4) of the calling of Moses: “The angel of Jehovah appeared to him in a flame of fire out of the midst of a thornbush, and he looked, and behold, the thornbush burned in the fire, and the thornbush was not consumed. Then Moses said: I will turn aside and see

this great sight, why the thornbush is not burnt up. But Jehovah saw that he turned aside to see, and God called to him out of the midst of the thornbush and said: Moses! Moses! and he said: behold, here am I". How it may be possible for faith to apprehend this description we can well enough understand, for faith sees everything in the light of imagination, and imagination knows how the supernatural combines with the rational, the validity of the laws with the interruption of the laws; but in knowledge and science it cannot be apprehended. Human knowledge is in everything, both the sensuous and the thinkable, so strictly bound to the natural, the merely rational, that it can neither hear God speak like a human being nor see how a thornbush can go on burning without being consumed by the fire. From this, then, it is clear that an object of faith must be of an entirely different nature from an object of knowledge. If we place two natural scientists, one on each side of Moses, they would be able to see the thornbush, as surely as it is an external, real thing, but they could not possibly either see the angel or hear Jehovah's word. The thornbush is an object of knowledge, but the angel and Jehovah are objects of faith. What can now be inferred from this? That the cognition of knowledge, the cognition of the natural, must be common to all the naturally gifted who make [8] rational use of sense and understanding, while the cognition of faith, the cognition of the supernatural, if indeed such a cognition really exists, is possible only for "the elect", for those who with a special sense for the supernatural can see what others cannot see, and hear what others cannot hear.

We see that there cannot possibly be a cognition without there being someone who cognizes and something that is cognized, although the relation is quite a different one in religion from what it is in science. That every cognition of the objective must presuppose an objectification, and every objectification an objectifying subjectivity, no one will deny who has thought seriously about the matter. There may be countless objects that no human being has yet objectified, and there may perhaps be objects for whose objectification the necessary conditions are lacking; but objects so objective that they can neither be experienced nor represented nor thought by any subjectivity whatsoever there cannot be. But if it stands unshakably firm that no object can be without a corresponding objectification, then it follows incontrovertibly that an objectifying subjectivity must extend just as far as the world of objects. Conversely, let subjectivity be as infinitely clear, as eternal and deep as one pleases, it must nevertheless vanish like an empty semblance when the last remnant of the objective disappears. Subjectivity is just as little able to objectify itself without presupposing an other that is not subjectivity as so-called pure space or pure time will have any subsistence when the actual, changeable

content is thought away. In principle, subjective and objective are opposed and yet mutually belonging determinations, which stand and fall with each other. To speak of what is objective for man is, in the language of religion as well as of science, to speak of what can be humanly objectified. The difference of objects is essentially conditioned by a different objectification, and the difference of objectification is grounded in the objectifying subjectivity.

Revelation, the objective of religion, can be objectified only in imagination. This [9] is by no means to assert that what is revealed is only an imagination. To maintain such an assertion would in itself be just as absurd as to assert that an object such as a stone, a rock, was only a sensation, because such things must necessarily be objectified through sensation. We do not here regard imagination as a creative faculty, but as a medium of cognition. It is necessary in science as well as in religion, but its use is just as different as scientific objectification is different from religious. In science the interest falls essentially on the objective, in religion on the other hand first and last on the subjective. A scientific objectification, e.g. of the solar system, presupposes imagination, but imagination is nevertheless not permitted to introduce a single member, not even a single feature, unless its reality has been sufficiently tested in experience and thinking. Although all knowledge, as we have seen, must necessarily presuppose a subjectivity determined for the objective, it is nevertheless an unavoidable demand in science that the objects not be colored by subjective light, but be apprehended, without any admixture of arbitrary elements or irrelevant additions, as they must be assumed to be in themselves according to universally valid laws. Whether such objects are pleasant or unpleasant to man, beneficial or harmful, has no influence on scientific objectification; the objects of science are in this sense impersonal. It is otherwise with the religious objects. In religion the objectifying subjectivity must take account of its own inner being, its fear, its hope, its need and passion, its peace and salvation. The objectification then sets the mind in motion, and imagination imparts a personal tinge to the objects. In the Psalms of David this feature is prominent in many ways. In Ps. XVIII. 7–18 it is said: “In my distress I called upon Jehovah ... Then the earth was shaken, so that it trembled, and the foundations of the mountains quaked ... He rode upon a cherub and flew, he soared on the wings of the storm. He pitched a tent of darkness as his shelter around him. It [10] was his hut, dark waters in thick clouds”. Here objectification takes place in imagination. Cf. Ps. LXV, Ps. CIV, Ps. CXIV etc.

That religion, even if in another and higher sense, needs the free use of imagination for its objectification of reality just as surely as poetry does, can be seen, among other

things, from the story of creation. When it is said in Gen. ch. 1 that the Spirit of God hovered over the waters, and that God said let there be light, the spirit becomes visible in the medium of imagination, and God himself appears as an object of faith in that he brings forth the light. By light and its opposite, darkness, is presumably meant sensuous light and sensuous darkness — “it became evening and it became morning” — but the sensuous dissolves into the supersensuous, for God is no sensuous thing, and the word: let there be light! can be heard only with the ear of faith. The scientific theory of light cannot discover the light that is created on the first day and precedes the luminous bodies, the great and the small light, which come into being only on the fourth day. Nor can science come to terms with herbs sprouting from the earth a whole day before the coming into being of the sun, the moon and the stars, any more than it can catch sight of the extended firmament that divides the waters above from those below. If faith is right, then science must be wrong. An endeavor to reconcile faith and knowledge by letting the six days designate six periods, each of several million years, is equally ruinous to religion and to science. By going along with this, religion of course departs from the clear words of the Bible about evening and morning, and finds no way of understanding ch. 2, v. 3, where God hallows the seventh day because he rested on it from all his work. Nor can science be served by such an agreement; it lacks an eye for the supernatural, and will not possibly be able to come to terms with herbs and trees having appeared millions of years before the sun came into being.

That the religious objectification of things and their connection is fundamentally different from the scientific, everyone who will take the trouble to understand the relation must necessarily concede. If we consider Paradise, the creation of woman and the Fall, Gen. II and III, the difference between faith and knowledge will show itself, [11] if possible, still more conspicuously. For the objectification of faith, Eden, the garden that God planted in the east and in which he put man, has not merely as much reality as any other garden, but infinitely more; for here the natural fuses harmoniously with the supernatural. The river that divides, the gold, bdellium and the stone shoham are natural, of course, the tree of life supernatural, and the tree of knowledge at once both natural and supernatural. Or should there perhaps be nothing natural at all in the tree of knowledge, how then is it possible that Eve, who after all cannot be altogether supernatural, can take delight in seeing it and eating of its fruit? But if the tree were not also supernatural, how then should it, besides the fruit of knowledge, be able to bear the talking serpent? That he who, John VIII, 44, is called the murderer from the beginning must have been in the serpent is likewise more supernatural than natural. It

has, to be sure, not seldom been declared that the whole account of Paradise and the Fall need not necessarily be understood literally, but could very well be taken either allegorically or mythically, without religious faith thereby suffering any detriment. That this, however, is a concession dangerous to revelation will readily strike the eye. It cannot be impressed strongly enough that all faith in revelation is in its principle, and must be, faith in miracles. Should the miraculous in Paradise really entitle us to take the whole account as a myth, then the same would of course have to hold of everything miraculous in the New as well as in the Old Testament. Christ's birth of the Virgin, his miracles, his resurrection and ascension must then dissolve into sheer myths. But when the miracle, in whatever shape it appears, is myth and revelation mythology, then religion is subject to the judgment of science, and its positive form is thereby essentially dissolved. If, then, one stands firmly on the principle that our cognition of truth can have only one principle, since the eternal, absolute truth is only one and must in all things be equal to itself: then the struggle between religion and science, between faith [12] and knowledge, is a struggle of life and death, as urgent and decisive as possible.

If it is really true, as faith in revelation teaches, that the history of mankind proceeds from a paradise, then it can not possibly be true, whatever natural history asserts, that man has come into being by developing out of some animal form or other; if it is really true that Christ is risen from the grave and bodily ascended — not to another globe in space, but to heaven, then there must somewhere be a real and yet super-real, natural and yet supernatural heaven, in which he dwells, a heaven that the astronomers do not know. Although all our cognition is piecemeal, there can nonetheless be no question of parceling out the truth itself, so that some rare, especially remarkable pieces, as e.g. where the law of gravity is suspended and one walks on the sea, or where the chemical laws are burst, and water is changed by a word into wine, belong to religion, while the more ordinary and natural pieces fall to science. The separation does not here concern the individual, now surprising, now more ordinary appearances of the truth; no, what is at issue here is a principle, the principle of the human cognition of the truth. If there is only one principle here, then it must necessarily be placed either in faith or in knowledge. If it is placed in faith, then science must unconditionally bow to religion; science does not know God and, however far back it looks, still cannot reach the beginning of creation. If we place the principle in knowledge, then religion must subordinate itself to science. One can then say to him who is not able to appropriate the great results of scientific research: In your simplicity you may well believe in Paradise and the Fall, in Christ's supernatural conception and ascension, in what is awakening and consoling for the

common people in these images and notions; but never imagine that it is really truth. Truth is only in science, and he who does not know science never comes to know what truth essentially is.

That there is only one principle of cognition will, in a practical sense, have the consequence that there can be only one supreme authority of truth, which must then be sought either in religion or in science. What follows from this, history has shown. In Catholicism throughout the whole Middle Ages, indeed even in the old Protestantism until toward the end of the seventeenth century, the principle was religious and the overreaching authority on the side of the Church; a scientific development of form was indeed also in motion, but as regards the content of truth, reason, darkened by the Fall, had to borrow its light from revelation, honor it as a maidservant (*ancilla*) honors her mistress, and resign itself to its captivity under “the obedience of faith.” If the principle of faith is to count as the only true principle of cognition, then it is perfectly consistent that the science in which the form of reason is compelled to develop the content of revelation, namely theology, must be regarded as the highest and properly true science. As regards other scientific endeavors, theology is therefore fully within its rights when, in cases of dispute, it summons them before its tribunal and judges them by its own laws. [13]

In the eighteenth century the relation begins to turn; not only in historical-philological criticism, but also in philosophy and natural science, which, despite strife and disagreement among themselves, were agreed in recognizing the right of reason, science emancipated itself from the authority of religion, declared outright that the true principle of cognition was not religious, but scientific. At first one sought to purge every trace of the unscientific and to transform religion itself into the highest science; when the mistake was discovered, science, by virtue of the solely valid rational principle, aimed directly at a radical dissolution of all positive religion. Those who still, in the name of revelation, would make faith in the supernatural the only true, all-embracing principle of cognition have dark prospects; for science, with reason and the natural world as its foundation, is a power, indeed a great power, that will not a second time let itself be gagged and put in chains. It would then have to happen by a miracle so great that the whole of modern culture collapsed into chaos.

As regards miracles, the Protestant Church has hardly been fortunate in its interpretation of the Bible. In the Gospel of Mark XVI. 15–18, the ascending Savior says: “Go into all the world and preach the gospel to the whole creation. He who believes and is baptized shall be saved, but he who becomes unbelieving shall be damned. But these signs shall accompany those who believe: in my name they shall cast out devils, they [14]

shall speak with new tongues; they shall take up serpents, and if they drink any poison, it shall not harm them; they shall lay their hands on the sick and they shall be healed.” No one will be able to deny that the general Church, from its standpoint, is right when, in unconditional reverence for Christ’s words, it lays decisive weight on faith and baptism as indispensable conditions for salvation and blessedness; but it must astonish us in the highest degree that the Protestant churches, even Bible-firm, orthodox Lutheranism, take no account whatever of the outward marks with which Christ himself, in the moment of parting, solemnly designates the believers. It is a polemic against Catholicism that has misled the Protestant Church into misjudging the indissoluble connection between biblical Christianity and its miracles. One is offended by the Catholic legends of the saints, the many petty, tasteless miracle tales, and so resorts to the, as it seems, very reasonable expedient of letting the age of miracles end with the death of the apostles and pure Christianity continue by the mysterious effects of the Word and the Sacrament alone, without visible miracles. In Holberg’s *Kirke-Historie*, Part 1² p. 31, it is said of Christianity: “No doctrine has been confirmed with so many and great miracles, although no doctrine needed signs less, and that in respect of its excellence; for all that Jesus taught on earth aims solely at the happiness of the human race, and one sees that its morality has had such an effect that barbarous lands, even at the times when the doctrine had been obscured by human inventions, have thereby received another shape. Yet [15] God has, as it were in superabundance, authorized it not only by the prophecies of the prophets, but by countless miracles, so that no one’s unbelief could be excused.” — But who does not now see that such a separation, which Holberg by no means invented, but expressly found already in the Lutheran Church, the separation between a Christianity with miracles and a Christianity without miracles, is something so altogether unknown in the New Testament that neither Christ nor the apostles seem to have had even the remotest inkling of it? By entering upon this separation the Lutheran Church, despite all protests, without being conscious of the contradiction, has transferred the principle of cognition from religion over into science and thereby dug its own grave. It is then incontrovertibly certain that revelation and reason, faith and knowledge, must wage an incessant, irreconcilable struggle with each other, until either religion has subjected all science to itself or, conversely, science has made itself master over all religion. If one cannot possibly accept the first supposition without violating science, and cannot possibly give oneself over to the latter view without violating religion and attacking the life of the people at its innermost root, then it becomes necessary to investigate

²Edited by Liebenberg. 1867.

whether the one, eternal, in itself absolute truth should not, by its reflection in human consciousness, be compelled to divide itself, to radiate from two different centers and thereby to deposit two relative, yet for all human cognition absolutely heterogeneous principles, the one for faith, the other for knowledge.

That the two spheres of truth, each with its center, cannot stand in conflict with each other follows from the fact that both have their origin in the one and same eternal unity of truth; but that they also cannot fuse together follows from the fact that their cognition, on account of the separation, must have a different point of departure, a different goal and a different method. The object of faith cannot possibly become an object of knowledge, nor conversely. Questions such as those about creation, Paradise and the Fall, redemption and restoration cannot be answered scientifically at all, and must therefore be resolutely turned away in science; whereas all questions about atoms, [16] forces, laws, about the natural formation and dissolution of things belong to science and do not concern religion at all. When a teacher of religion sallies forth with a supposedly decisive polemic against science and would have its criticism of the biblical doctrine of creation, of the miracles, etc., prove that science is false, he proves only that scientific cognition neither is nor will nor can be religious, precisely because it is and must be scientific. When conversely someone in the name of science proves that such notions as those of Paradise and the Fall, resurrection from the dead, etc., must be completely eradicated because they are all encumbered with intolerable contradictions: then such proofs have significance exclusively from a scientific, not from a religious standpoint. Religion can, with its principle, when it speaks outright, openly and freely declare that it is and must be unscientific. Neither Abraham nor Moses nor Christ was a man of science or spoke out of deeper scientific presuppositions; their grounds are personal, and the objects of cognition, which are seen in the light of personality, thereby all without exception receive a personal tinge. The religious person can in his own way take all human powers into service without making use of science; there runs through the Old and New Testament a rich and deep and mighty stream of thoughts, but they have essentially nothing to do with science. Science can, according to its principle, declare outright that it is at bottom neither Christian nor Jewish nor pagan, but universally rational, and must seek its original independence solely and only in the universally rational.

Only when this fundamental separation, this dualism of temporality into which the eternal enters, is fully recognized and held fast, can there be talk of true reciprocal action between the religious and the scientific in human life. The eternal, absolute truth,

which in its essence is monistic, enters into temporality and becomes dualistic; man, in whom this dualism comes to clear consciousness, cannot be rid of the dualism either by ascetic-unscientific denial of the reality of the temporal or by nihilistic-scientific denial [17] of the reality of the eternal, but must, in dualistic cognition of both realities, work his way forward in approximation toward an ever richer understanding of the absolutely true, concrete monism.

By briefly illuminating the historical misrelations between religion and science, we shall in what follows attempt to work our way toward a standpoint from which it can be seen that religion can just as little be the guardian of science as science the guardian of religion, but that both, precisely by virtue of the two heterogeneous principles, can work together in good understanding.

II.

If revealed religion is the truth itself, and the cognition of truth only one, then reason has no particular principle of cognition. Revelation must then be infinitely exalted above man's limited reason, darkened by sin; not even the explanation of the natural order of things may be left to a reasonable use of the understanding and the five senses alone, for the senses, after all, extend only to what is lower, and the thinking left to reason is exposed to great errors. Luther, who otherwise ranks reason high in all worldly, civil matters, demonstrates its complete impotence and insufficiency when the talk is of answering decisive religious questions; in particular, in the eucharistic controversy he so brushed aside the Carlstadtian reason that he thereby palpably struck the universally human one. One would then think that the Lutheran Church, even if by a suitable use of a subordinate reason it could obtain a well-ordered and coherent doctrine of religion, could not possibly succeed in obtaining a dogmatics so scientifically, many-sidedly grounded as the scholastic Catholic one. And yet it has happened. The Lutherans' confession of faith has to such a degree developed into science that dogmatics has become the decisive norm for true orthodoxy. Melancthon, who with his *Loci Theologici* began religiously [18] and ended scientifically, led the way; but since he could not properly get the better of reason and in particular could not open his eyes to the fact that the highest must be precisely what is contrary to reason, his tendency was seriously combated. Only in the *Formula Concordiæ* is it expressly laid down how reason is unconditionally subject to orthodoxy, must humble itself under what is above reason, indeed bow deeply before what is contrary to reason, and now the doctrine of religion became orthodox-systematic. Religion again became science in becoming theology. Like an eagle on mighty wings the reborn theology rose in the sunlight of revelation to such a height that it could freely

look down on and judge all the human knowledge that had to keep to the earth. How matters really stand with this orthodox science we shall seek to illuminate in a few strokes.

As the all-embracing principle of cognition, faith has Holy Scripture as its foundation; the first concern, then, is to secure the infallibility of Scripture by securing its verbal inspiration. It had to be proved, and was then, if not properly proved, at any rate asserted in faith, that prophets and apostles have not written a single word from natural impulse or on their own account, but that it expressly took place according to the immediate prompting of the Holy Spirit. Every word of the Bible is then in the proper sense God's word; the instruments chosen for the writing down are "God's scribes, God's pens." That the authority of Scripture does not, as the Catholics assert, depend on the authority of the Church, but on God alone, can be seen from manifold passages of Scripture, John V, 34; VII, 17; 1 Thess. II, 13 and others³. The purpose of God's having himself willed to communicate his will to us in writing is solely that we should learn to worship him in the right way and to conduct our life so that we can surely attain blessedness⁴. The clarity, completeness and accuracy of Scripture is so great that even the vowels in the Old Testament must be assumed to be inspired. That no contradictions can possibly be [19] shown between different passages of Scripture where the same thing is expressly spoken of is self-evident. It can undeniably go so far that Jehovah is expressly said in one place to do what Satan does in another, as when it is related in 2 Samuel XXIV, 1 that Jehovah himself tempted David, while it is said in 1 Chron. XXI, 1 that it was Satan who tempted him; but this can very well be explained if only one is willing to take reason captive. That Jehovah tempts means, after all, that he cannot tempt — "Let no one say, when he is tempted: I am tempted by God; for God is not tempted by evil, and he himself tempts no one" (James I, 13). Since, then, Jehovah in his wrath wants to tempt David, it is surely not incomprehensible that he lets Satan do what he himself cannot; only let one beware of the subtlety of reason that would have Jehovah himself, with respect to the temptation, be in agreement with Satan. Nor, as regards the purely historical, can the sacred authors be assumed, as the Socinians nonetheless assert, to have erred here and there. To be sure, there are several difficult passages even in the New Testament. It is indeed a great question, concerning Luke II, 1–2, whether Quirinius was precisely governor in Syria when the Emperor Augustus had all the world enrolled for taxation; it is, if possible, an even more difficult question how the prophet Jeremiah, Matt. XXVII, 9, can be exchanged for Zechariah. If one cannot take reason captive, one must admit a

³See e.g. Brochmand. *Universæ Theologiæ Systema*. Articuli II. Cap. II p. 14–15.

⁴Op. cit. Cap. I. p. 2.

lapse of memory; but when faith has become the master of reason, one sees at once that Jeremiah may very well have said what not he himself, but Zechariah wrote⁵.

Since the Bible, however, is subject to interpretation, and every interpreter is driven by his spirit, there arises the serious question: by which interpretation, then, is one to know the true Spirit? Luther's declaration: "*Der heilige Geist ist der allereinfältigste Schreiber und Redner, der im Himmel und Erden ist, darum auch seine Worte nicht mehr denn einen einfältigen Sinn haben können, welchen wir den schriftlichen oder buchstablichen Zungen-sinn nennen*"⁶ gives us a provisional guidance. Only in the spirit of the Bible can the Bible be interpreted; the spirit of the Bible is the Holy Spirit, consequently the interpreter must have the same Holy Spirit if his interpretation is to be true. When Jesus was baptized by John, it is said: "then the heavens were opened above him," as he went up out of the water, "and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and coming upon him." And behold, from the heavens there came a voice, which said: "this is my Son, the beloved, in whom I am well pleased." Matt. III, 16–17; in Luke III, 22 it is expressly said that the Holy Spirit descended in bodily shape like a dove (καταβῆναι τὸ πνῦμα τὸ ἅγιον σωματικῶς εἶδει). If one is now to take this quite simply according to the letter, then a clear and definite notion of how the Spirit looked in a real dove-shape is difficult, for he who looks simply at the dove cannot see the Spirit, and he who fixes his gaze on the Spirit cannot see the dove; it becomes equally difficult to understand whether it was Jesus alone who saw the dove and heard the voice, or John as well. When one reads the Gospel of John I, 15–32, III, 27–36, one would indeed think that the Baptist himself had both seen the dove and heard the voice; but if we compare with this Matt. XI, 2 and 3, and Luke VII, 18–35, one is tempted to doubt that the Baptist was really in agreement with himself about what he had actually seen and heard. [20]

The relation between spirit and letter is by no means so comprehensible as it might seem at first glance. If we begin with the literal meaning, then reason and understanding have so much to do with the meaning of words and with context, with grammar and hermeneutics, that exegesis, taken scientifically, easily forgets the Holy Spirit; and yet it is the Spirit that gives understanding its right stamp. That there is spirit in the Catholic Church just as well as in the Protestant ones, surely no one will deny. These churches lie in conflict with one another precisely because each of them claims to have the true [21]

⁵Brochmand. Systema, Part 1, p. 81: *Nobis tutissima responsio est hæc: verba illa qvæ a Matth. adscribuntur Jeremiæ, a Jeremiæ quidem dicta esse, (non enim dicit Evangelista, hoc a Jeremiæ scriptum, sed ῥηθὲν ceu dictum est): verum a Zaeharia in litteras sacras relata. Nam aliæ qvæ afferri solent responsiones, aut Textum græccum corruptelæ arguunt, aut Matthæo dicam lapsus memoriæ scribunt, aut conjecturis plane incertis nituntur.*

⁶Walch XVIII 1602.

spirit of revelation. Catholics, Zwinglians, Calvinists each claim for themselves to have the Holy Spirit in preference to the Lutherans; how is this conflict now to be settled by invoking the Spirit? We hear Luther inveigh against the false prophets: “*Schrift, Schrift, Schrift aber ist nicht eitel Geist, davon sie geifern, der Geist müsste es allein thun; die Schrift sei ein todter Buchstabe, und könne nicht das Leben geben. Rühme aber nicht viel vom Geiste, wenn du nicht das aeusserliche offenbare Wort hast, denn es wird gewisslich nicht ein guter Geist sein, sondern der leidige Teufel aus der Hölle.*” We can agree with Luther in this, and yet get not a hair’s breadth further; his words to the Zwinglians at the Colloquy of Marburg 1529: “*Ihr habt einen andern Geist denn wir,*” show clearly enough what the invoked unity of body and bread, of blood and wine, amounts to. If the decisive thing is to lie in faith, then everyone must of course abide by his faith; the Zwinglian then has the very same right as the Lutheran. Even if the words of institution: “this is my body, this is my blood,” are taken and used quite according to the letter, there is nevertheless in the letter itself no understanding; the understanding, which comes with the interpretation, must necessarily become either reasonable: “this signifies,” or contrary to reason: “this is what it nevertheless cannot yet be, either naturally or supernaturally.” When Christ distributed bread and wine, he still had, after all, his own natural body and blood; if the bread and the wine are *not merely to signify*, but in a *supernatural manner to be* the natural body that is to be given up, the natural blood that is to be shed on the cross, then we must necessarily get either an altogether incomprehensible ambiguity, or a mystery so impenetrable that faith itself must cling to the absurd — *credo quia absurdum est*. But the absurd gives not only no scientific, but also no religious understanding; it halts every possible apprehension by the absolutely meaningless. To a such a consequence [22] the Lutheran Church has not been able to surrender itself; it has remained standing by faith, i.e., by *its* faith in the mystery.

Now if each particular church community must be conscious of having a particular faith, then it must of course also have particular formulas for its distinctive confession of faith, particular symbols. When the faith of the church is then to be built solely and exclusively on Holy Scripture, the validity of the symbols must necessarily rest on their agreeing precisely with the doctrine of Scripture. The Lutheran Church does not claim that its symbols are infallible; it holds to them only *because (quia)* and *insofar as (qvatenus)* their content is in essential agreement with the content of Scripture. But here the question of interpretation comes up again, for the movement goes in a circle. An interpretation without a particular confession of faith can be reasonable, acute, profound, and yet not true, because the Spirit of truth is lacking; but the Spirit of truth is the Spirit

of faith, and true faith lives only in the true Church. For the Lutheran, the spirit of the Lutheran Church must be one with the Holy Spirit of revelation; the Lutheran must thus understand the symbols in the spirit of the Bible, but from this it follows conversely that he must interpret the Bible in the spirit of the symbols; if he deviates from this rule, i.e., if he breaks the circle, he becomes a heretic.

If we now cast a glance at the dogmas, it is not what is peculiar to the individual churches but what is common to them all, the universal, on which we shall dwell in this connection. The Fall is brought about by a temptation of the Devil; the restoration is owed exclusively to the merit of Christ. To demonstrate the scientific character of dogmatics as a whole, we therefore need only cast a glance at the relation between Christ and the Devil in Lutheran dogmatics. Whether Christ would have become incarnate if man had not sinned (*atiamsi homo non peccasset*), a question which Thomas Aquinas treats at length⁷, the Lutheran Church has not undertaken to decide⁸; but it has instead [23] investigated in great detail the relation between Christ's divine and human nature, and has thereby made it quite clear how He who was revealed in order to "*destroy the works of the Devil*" really had the power to complete his mission. Although the Devil's power was really broken when Christ revealed himself, the Devil's kingdom nevertheless continues to the last to resist the kingdom of Christ. Luther's faith in a real, personal Devil was just as unshakable as his faith in a real, personal Christ. Luther agrees with Tertullian that not only evil thoughts and desires, but also crop failure, pestilence, fire and other external misfortunes have the Devil as their author. In the *Catechismus major* and in many other places Luther seeks in the most urgent manner to impress upon us how persistent, many-sided and untiring the activity of the devils and demons is, so that we may be on our guard. "*Die Heiden*," he says, "*wissen nicht, woher das Unglück so plötzlich kommt; aber wir wissen es, das es eitel Teufels Arbeit ist, der hat solche Helleparten, Bleikugeln und Büchsen, solche Spiesse und Schwerter, damit er unter uns schiesst, wirft und sticht, wenn Gott es ihm erlaubt ...*"; and in another place: "*Ein Christ soll wissen, dass er mitten unter den Teufeln sitze, und dass ihm der Teufel näher sei den sein Rock oder Hemde, ja näher denn seine eigene Haut, dass er rings um uns her sei, und wir also stets mit ihm zu Haar liegen und uns mit ihm schlagen müssen*"⁹.

It is, however, not Luther's personal authority but that of the Bible, namely the fundamental doctrine of the New Testament, that makes it necessary for Lutheran dogmatics to build, if we may say so, on belief in the Devil, and to follow the arch-

⁷Gent. IV c. 53, 55. Cf. Dr. Karl Werner. Der heilige Thomas von Aquino 1859. 2ter Band. p. 620.

⁸Brochmd. p. 725–26.

⁹Cf. Walch. X, p. 1234, XIII, p. 2550.

enemy's struggle against the kingdom of Christ until the Day of Judgment, when he himself with all his followers shall be bound forever in hell. The Lutheran dogmaticians are for that reason just as careful to investigate how far the Devil can actually go, and on what his power rests, as to develop faith in the merit of Christ¹⁰. In this matter we must grant that Strauss is right when he maintains "that the idea of the Messiah and his kingdom is as little possible without a kingdom of demons, with a personal head as its counterpart, as the north pole of a magnet without a south pole"; we must concede to him that "the pious narrow-mindedness which feared to lose Christ if they lost the Devil has seen far more correctly than Schleiermacher with his postulate that belief in the Devil could in no way be set up as a condition for faith in Christ"¹¹. [24]

The orthodox Lutheran dogmatics, whose flowering falls in the seventeenth century, must surely be regarded as an attempt, serious of its kind, to present the undistorted content of the Bible in strictly scientific form, a truly magnificent attempt; but it was bound reason that, as the slave of faith, had to carry out the whole work; reason thus gradually became conscious of its powers, drew the principle of cognition over to itself little by little, and thereby prepared its complete emancipation. The Devil, who with his demons had mistreated it above all, was now himself to furnish the footstool on which it stood when it began to rise to its full height. A Reformed theologian in Holland, Balthasar Bekker, a zealous adherent of the Cartesian philosophy, published a highly sensational work, "The Bewitched World",¹² in which he combats belief in the influence of evil spirits, demonic possessions, witches and the like. Relying on reason, he demonstrates the ignorance in which the many absurd accounts of the Devil and his manifestations in paganism, Judaism, Mohammedanism and Christianity had to be assumed to have their origin. The narratives of the New Testament about the demoniacs he explains in a natural way, and he assumes that Jesus himself only meant to reform the moral element in faith without disturbing ingrained notions. On the story of the temptation he expresses himself, taking the Fall as his starting point, among other things as follows: "Denn vor fest und ungezweifelt anzunehmen, dass ein geschaffener Geist, und der von Gott verworfen ist, auff des Menschen Seele oder Leib wircken könne, davon ist schon hier vornen angezeigt, wie viel daran lieget. Hat der Satan eusserlich solch Gespräch mit dem Menschen geführt, da die Welt erst den Anfang hatte, wie lieset man das nicht mehr? Selbst nach Verlauff von viertausend Jahren in der berühmten Unterredung mit dem andern Adam, [25]

¹⁰See e.g. Brochmand II. Tom. I p. 250. Qvæst. XIII. An Diabolus cogitationes cordis novisse posse. Pg. 251. Qvæst. XIV. An Diabolus vera miracula edere qvæat. Pg. 253. Qvæst. XV. An Diabolus animas demortuorum in hanc vitam revocare, et substantiales rerum formas immutare possit? etc. etc.

¹¹Die christliche Glaubenslehre von Dr. D. F. Strauss. Zweiter Band. 1841. p. 15.

¹²De betoverede weereld, Amsterd. 1691–94. In German: Die bezauberte Welt.

da der Teufel zwar ausdrücklich genennet wird, ist das nicht geschehen. Denn obschon beydes Lucas und Mattheus das umständlich erzehlen, so muss man sich dennoch wol hüten, dass man nicht alles nach dem Buchstaben verstehe. Oder man müste zugleich glauben, dass Moses und Elias beyde eben so wol auff dem Berge persönlich gewesen und sich mit dem Seligmacher unterredet haben, wie solches ein andermahl, ja dreymahl wird erzehlet. Matth. XVII, 3. Marc. IX, 4. Luc. IX, 30, 31. Gleichwol war Moses nicht leiblich wie Elias in den Himmel auffgenommen worden, sondern gestorben und gar gewiss begraben, denn Gott hat es selbst gethan. Deut. XXXIV, 6. War er nun denn von den Todten auferstanden und leibhaftig gen Himmel gefahren: Wunder, dass die Schrift ein so grosses Wunder nicht meldet. Wer denn von solchen, als im Gesichte geschehen ist, so redet, als etwas das nach dem Buchstaben verstanden wird, der weiss, wie Petrus, auch nicht was er saget”.¹³

But if we see from this that reason cannot tolerate the Devil and therefore falls upon his flanks wherever he shows himself, then it also becomes intelligible to us that free reason, once its eye has been opened and criticism has properly begun, cannot confine itself to pursuing the Devil, but, taking its bearings over all the Bible’s domains, must [26] have the right to consider how it can come about that Moses, who was buried by God himself, and Elijah, who went up alive to heaven, could appear on one and the same mountain; it is, when we look more closely, not the Devil alone but the miracles that are an offense to free reason. One will likewise see that reason, once it has got hold of the principle of cognition, cannot be different in the different churches, but must rise above the confessional limitations. That the Reformed Church has a different confession of faith from the Lutheran is certain, but who would infer from this that reason itself must be different for the Lutherans than for the Reformed? The Reformed pastor was deposed for his “*Bezauberte Welt*”, but his book nonetheless found acceptance among all reasonable people in the Lutheran (Semler and Thomasius) as well as in the Reformed Church. In Denmark not only has Holberg’s wit made a considerable clearance among Satan’s papers, but the rationalism that began with him has, if with slow and cautious steps, approached the altar.

On the transition from orthodoxy to rationalism stands Christian Bastholm, a thinker unprejudiced for his time and respectable. Bastholm’s reason is finished with the Devil to such a degree that he is not even expressly named in the dogmatics¹⁴, p. 265, where the story of the temptation is touched on. “The seducer of the world,” it says, “presents himself to him” (Christ); “many and great trials are put to his innocence; but he wins the victory over them all. This temptation was necessary in several respects; before he

¹³Op. cit. p. 135–136 ff.

¹⁴Den Christl. Religions Hoved-Lærdomme. Kiøbhvn. 1783.

began to associate with men, he had to come to know man, his frailties and his afflictions, so that his own experience might instill in him tender feelings for the misery of men and their weaknesses" ... One would, however, be notably mistaken if one concluded from this that Bastholmian reason was now also agreed with itself to pass sentence on everything supernatural and to reject the miracles. As reason sneaks the principle of cognition over to itself, it does so with such caution, not to say dexterity, that the less attentive reader notices almost nothing. Of "Jesus' Miraculous Works" it says, among other things, p. 307 ff., "that they exceeded all the forces of nature and suspended its best-known laws ... We do not at all fear that anyone will ever carry his knowledge of nature so far that he shall put the works of Jesus to shame, that he should be able to heal the sick merely by a command, merely by the laying on of a hand, or merely by touching him, or that by his mere will he should heal those who are even absent. We do not at all fear that anyone should ever bring his insights into nature to such a height that merely by rebuking the waves and the storm winds he should stop them in the midst of their raging, or, by calling to the fish of the sea, should gather them in the same instant. If it were ever possible to do by the forces of nature the same works that Jesus Christ has done, then one ought surely to be able to find some traces of this hope already in our times, after the great strides that have been made, and the height that has been reached, in all the natural sciences. But of this there is not even the slightest trace." "But in this there is of course nothing unreasonable; if Christ really is the one he said he was, the revelation of divine truth, then it is of course entirely reasonable that he has been able to do works which otherwise surpass all human powers." "This inference," it says, p. 318, "is so simple that the simplest can grasp it. On this our reason grounds its tranquility and its conviction; more it need not know." In the doctrine of "The Apostles' Miraculous Works" it says, p. 404, 405 ff.: "By a wonder we understand a change in nature which either exceeds or is contrary to the forces of nature and its laws, at least at the time when it occurs ... That such wonders are possible, no one can doubt who knows the omnipotence of the infinite Being. The laws of nature are not in themselves necessary; they are only emanations of the free will of the Creator, who has arranged nature as it is, has granted creatures the powers they possess, and has thus connected causes with their effects as we now find them. But he who has given a law can also suspend it, when wise purposes demand it" ... "If the Creator once by free choice gave fire the power to shine and to burn, then he can also deprive it of this power again, or hinder its effect" ... All this now looks quite reasonable. How reasonable the whole of revelation has become in Bastholm's conception can be seen, among other things, from the chapter on "Jesus' [27]

Ascension”, p. 369–382. “After Christ had walked about for 40 days with his disciples ... he left the earth with his visible presence, in order to take possession of heaven ... It is the order which the Lord’s wisdom has established, that after the tribulations of life follows death, after death the resurrection, and after the resurrection an eternal possession of heavenly bliss in soul and body. Now Christ had died, he had risen; nothing was therefore more natural than that he should now take possession of the blessings of heaven ... Reason therefore finds nothing unreasonable in the doctrine that Jesus Christ ... was taken up into heaven, in order to take possession of the glory and bliss that belonged to him as God-man ... If one can here, as with the resurrection of Christ, prove that it was impossible either that the apostles could themselves be deceived in this event, or that they could wish to deceive us with a false testimony, then the faith that we place in their report of it is well founded and reasonable.” Christ, in the author’s opinion, used four means to convince the apostles and posterity that no deception had taken place, that what was seen here had not been a delusion of the senses and imagination, but full reality. “First, this was a piece of Jesus’ wisdom, that he did not vanish among them. After his resurrection he was sometimes wont to appear among them quite unexpectedly, and again to vanish before their eyes just as unexpectedly; perhaps he wished thereby to convince them that the body which he had brought out of the grave at the resurrection had other and higher properties than the body that had been laid in the grave. But now, when he would leave the earth, another purpose demanded another procedure ... Our Redeemer was slowly and visibly taken up into heaven ... The second piece of Jesus’ [29] wisdom was this, that he chose the Mount of Olives from which to make his ascension. No place could be more convenient for this purpose. This mountain lay a Sabbath day’s journey from Jerusalem; they thus had opportunity enough to see and observe Jesus in the free and open air. He spoke with them on the way, gave them his commands, repeated his promise of the Holy Spirit, whom he would send them, and blessed them ... This mountain was also the highest mountain around Jerusalem; here there was thus a free view and a purer air, which afforded them a convenient opportunity to behold so important an event quite unhindered.” The third piece of Jesus’ wisdom must strike us in particular as bearing a predominant stamp of reasonableness. “One asks why Christ did not here assemble all his enemies, in order by so great a wonder to convince them all at once of their unbelief and of his divine mission? I could answer much to this question; I could answer that they would have let themselves be convinced by this wonder just as little as by all the others ... The Jews ascribed his other miraculous works to the Devil; they could thus say the same about this one. When a man is hardened to such a degree,

proofs are of no more use ... I therefore see no reason why Christ should ascend in the sight of his enemies; but I see an important reason why he should not do so. Had Christ publicly announced at what time and at what place he would ascend into heaven, he would undeniably have drawn all the inhabitants of Jerusalem after him; for who does not feel the power of curiosity, and who would not walk a little way to be a spectator of so extraordinary an event? But what noise, what tumult and disorder must there not necessarily have been in so numerous a swarm, where one pushes the other, where each wants to be the nearest, and one drives off the other, as on a stormy sea one wave drives the other." Surely something of the most reasonable that can be said in a scientific dogmatics.

In Bastholm the principle of reason still lies, if we may say so, swaddled in the supranatural and kicking in its swaddling clothes; but in German literature reason [30] had already earlier become conscious of its superiority. The Wolffian philosophy so thoroughly permeated the Wertheim Bible translation¹⁵ that the Spirit of God cannot hover over the waters, but "a violent wind" must begin to blow; the concepts are defined so sharply that for the understanding of Lev. XVIII, 7 it must even be added, for clarity's sake, what a mother is, namely "a woman who begets children in company with a man". The bookseller and author Nicolai in Berlin published from 1765 to 1805 the "*Allgemeine*" and "*Neuallgemeine deutsche Bibliothek*", in which reason became quite popular. The theologians themselves worked along at the enlightenment of Germany. The Provost of Cölln, Wilh. Albr. Teller, gave a public reply to an open letter from Jewish heads of household in Berlin, in which he declared himself willing to acknowledge them as Christians on the basis of their mere deism. Greater liberality one could hardly demand; it is as if we heard the very voice of reason. "In the year 1833, e.g., the Evangelical General Superintendent Röhr's '*Predigerbibliothek*' called the doctrine of all Christian churches concerning the triune God an '*antichristian dogma*' (1833, H. 1. p. 11), and called Augustine, on account of his doctrine of sin and grace, and because he had not remained unconverted, one 'who desecrated the Gospel, and a dissolute man who had become one of the saints' (ibid. p. 13), but Pelagius (p. 15) 'the venerable defender of reason against unreason, a man who already in his own time had the satisfaction of seeing the wisest and best stand on his side', (calling the Evangelical Church fortunate (p. 16) if only Luther had not merely reformed back to the father of his order, Augustine), and declared (p. 48): 'Supranaturalism leads away from the worship of God to the worship of idols' etc.; indeed, in that same year 1833, the above-mentioned high clergyman, and that not merely

¹⁵Erster Theil, 1735.

privatim, but quite publicly and with *ecclesiastical force of law*, presented the foundation of the whole of Christianity, the word of the cross, the doctrine of Christ's death, 'a death of redemption and atonement *for the good of men* ("for the expiation of human wickedness") endured', as 'a consequence of the total corruption of the pure Gospel', as [31] 'a fiction of ignorant and hair-splitting church teachers'. Indeed, one went still further – from Halle the fall of all dogmas was proclaimed (*Halliche Allg. Lit. Zeitung*; März 1833 Ergänz. Bl. p. 234, decidedly expresses the hope that 'when all Christian dogmas fall, sooner or later', all men would at last unite on a Christian morality).¹⁶

Vulgar rationalism was, however, too superficial to be able to satisfy profound spirits; for that a speculative reason was required, one capable of seeing through the identity of the supernatural with the natural. Dogmaticians such as Daub and Marheinecke looked down on the rationalists, but up to Schelling and Hegel. Here one found a development of reason so deep and so wide-ranging that it held the whole of Christianity. When representation had been dissolved into concept, theology all at once became so orthodox that the Devil himself went along into the concept. When reason, by making its principle of knowledge into the principle of revelation, was on the very point of devouring the whole positive content of orthodoxy, it became so speculatively swollen that it was close to losing its understanding. Things might really have looked grave for its precious life, had one not come in good time to the aid of the swollen patient with a radical and cleansing remedy; this remedy was a purgative criticism, applied above all by Dr. Strauss.

However much one may regret that Strauss has been blind to the divine essence of religion, one must nonetheless, on behalf of science, be grateful to him that his critical treatment both of the life of Jesus and of church dogmatics, even if there may be a good deal to object to in the details, has shown that religious faith must perish when it is to be justified in knowledge, i.e., when religion is to be conceived and grounded scientifically. "Strauss's talent consists in uncovering the confusion and annihilating [32] the illusions; but his criticism is only *dissolving*, the result remains *negative*." "His dogmatics is no dogmatics, but only a critique of the individual dogmas, a repertory of dogmatic representations. Despite all neatness in the external ordering and delimitation of the material, and despite the sureness of the tendency of understanding, an enormous lack is nevertheless perceptible, and the nihilistic background produces a feeling of disconsolateness and emptiness"¹⁷. This view must surely be approved by all who still expect a new theology from science, but it is precisely this expectation that the Straussian

¹⁶H. E. F. Guerike. *Haandbog i Kirkehistorien*. Transl. by Sverdrup. Christiania. 1842. Anden Deel. p. 338 note.

¹⁷Dr. Karl Schwarz. *Den nyeste Theologies Historie*. Danish translation. Kjøbenhavn. 1879. p. 779.

criticism is expressly designed to annihilate. That he has accomplished his task in this respect is entirely beyond doubt. One may remodel rationalism as much as one likes; the rational principle will never become religious. K. Schwarz commends Hase's rational theology. "The principle governing everything in his dogmatics," he says¹⁸, "was of course man's *relative freedom*, and the love for the kingdom of God grounded on it. The Trinity that he developed was also quite different from Schelling's, which turned into a physical world-event, a theogonic process, whereas with him it was ethical and was led back to the practical-biblical content. In general he asserted, in full consciousness, the ethical character of his theological system, and grounded it on man's moral-religious freedom in his independence before God, and on his love and infinite striving for communion with God, as on the firmest foundation. This ethical principle is indeed the imperishable kernel of truth in rationalism."

But the ethical principle is of course not a specifically scientific principle. Reason can postulate the reality of freedom and recommend to men in practical life that they assume it and believe in it; but it is not with freedom as it is with natural things. Everything that science is to be able to prove, it must prove in virtue of either absolute or conditional necessity; but when freedom itself is grounded on necessity, then scientific reason [33] can with full right doubt its reality. Still less can love of God ground any scientific assurance of God's love, of God's personality, any more than a personal need for an eternal life can furnish scientific proof of the immortality of the soul. That reason with its principle should really ground a doctrine of the Trinity which scientifically led back to the "practical-biblical content" is an assertion that betrays an utterly unclear confusion of the character of faith and of knowledge, and constantly mistakes religious representations for scientific facts, thoughts of revelation for universal thoughts of reason.

The God of religion, however one turns and twists the matter, is, as the God of freedom and of love, a supernatural being. Now if it can truly be said that reason, in all its scientific character, has no eye for the supernatural, then neither has it any eye for the God of freedom, of personality and of love. Reason must, passing over the miraculous—indeed, insofar as it is to make its principle valid, denying the miraculous—in creation as well as in the incarnation and in inspiration, hold strictly to nature and its laws. Where, then, will "rational theology" go with its love of God and its exalted ideal of freedom? It must seek its deity in nature and bind it to the laws of nature; it must give up freedom and deify necessity. — He who would pay homage to Comte's religion is, after all, compelled either to go beyond reason at a venture, or to turn back and bow to Littré's criticism.

¹⁸Op. cit. p. 413.

III.

That religion cannot appropriate the principle of cognition in its whole extent and thereby draw science under itself has been shown in the foregoing; the question now [34] becomes whether science with its principle of reason can then master religion, or whether, perhaps, by pursuing its own goal and discovering an essential limit, it will come to see the necessity of granting religion a distinctive principle of faith. To see how matters stand in this respect, let us cast a glance at the paths of science. It has fought, and with its principle must still constantly fight, its way forward through a double series of oppositions, the one indispensable, the other in a high degree obstructive and troublesome. Among the indispensable oppositions we count all those that spring from a genuine interest in the advancement of science, objections by whose answering errors committed are removed and method is secured; among the hampering, troublesome and encumbering ones, on the other hand, we must count the oppositions and objections that come from the uninformed, who from one interest or another would gladly bring science to a halt. It is, for the sake of the principle, especially to the latter that we must direct attention.

Nicolaus Copernicus, who already in 1530 had his new world system¹⁹ finished, nevertheless let it be printed only in 1543, and touched the first copy with a dying hand. That it was not so much fear of the polemic of the Ptolemaic astronomers as, far more, of that of the theologians and priests that held him back can be seen from his dedication to Pope Paul III, in which he foresees that empty babblers (ματαιόλογοι), devoid of all mathematical knowledge, will presume to pass judgment on the work by willfully distorting some passage or other in Holy Scripture (*propter aliquem locum scripturæ male ad suum propositum detortum*); and this presentiment was indeed fulfilled abundantly enough. Tycho Brahe's observations, Kepler's laws, Galileo's discovery of the moons of Jupiter, and finally Newton's mathematical Principles (1689) mark magnificent advances in a period in which church orthodoxy otherwise held the sciences in chains. No doubt the theologians must have been embittered at these ungodly theories, for although they did not properly understand them, this much was clear, that they must serve to [35] undermine the authority of the Bible; but what were they to do? The vault of heaven burst, new solar systems appeared; the earth shrank in a manner highly unbecoming for Christ and Christians. At last, at the transition from the eighteenth to the nineteenth century, the Creator was pushed back, the globes were allowed to form themselves out of a primeval nebula, and in all formations one kept to matter, forces and laws.

Not everything, to be sure, was settled by this. Though the theologian could not

¹⁹De Revolutionibus orbium coelestium, Norimbergæ MDXLIII.

follow the astronomer on the steep paths among the stars, he could still console himself that the common people could not do so either. If it would never become really evident to the people what the scientific extravagances of the astronomers signified, then one could simply ignore them, provided one only took care to keep the almanac clean. The point, then, was to meet science not in the immeasurable space of the heavens but on the solid earth, and here to prevent its deviation from the word of revelation in Scripture. But here too science has taken power from theology. Geology, the doctrine of the earth's gradual development, is no doubt still so young that its shape may constantly change; but this much is already clear, that it conforms not to the biblical doctrine of creation but to the facts of nature. The oppositions it has to contend with all fall within science itself; objections from a supernatural standpoint it does not heed at all. It is, no doubt, only rarely that theologians seriously engage with geology, but when it occasionally happens, they tend to betray a colossal misunderstanding. Thus, e.g., the theologian Tholuck²⁰ speaks strong words, especially on the occasion of a couple of other theologians' appreciative statements about geology. *“Die Erfahrungswissenschaften aller Art, heisst es... (Bretschneider in his Sendschreiben), haben fühlbarer und störender in den Bestand des alten theologischen Lehrsystems eingegriffen, als die spekulative Philosophie... [36] Die Geologie will die mosaische Schöpfung nicht mehr mit den Revolutionen, die unser Erdball erlitten hat, einstimmig finden. Sie lehrt, unbekümmert, wie der Theologe dabei zurechtkomme, dass die Erde mehrere grosze Bildungsperioden von unbestimmbarer aber langer Zeit durchgegangen ist, und dass die ersten Schöpfungen auf ihr wieder untergegangen sind”*. *“Die erhabene Wissenschaft der Astronomie war es..., welche in die Begriffe des Alterthums von Himmel, Erde, Hölle, Auferstehung, Gericht, Ende der Welt, die noch zur Zeit der Reformation unverändert waren, auflösend eingriff — die Naturforscher und Reisebeschreiber schilderten die Verschiedenheit der Racen an Gestalt, Farbe und geistigen Kräften, die durch die Vermischung der Racen entstehenden Spielarten, und wiesen die grossen und bleibenden Unterschiede unter ihnen nach, indem sie zeigten, dass diese Differenzen nicht auf Rechnung des Klimas und der Nahrung, sondern auf Verschiedenheit der Grundabstammung sich gründen müssen. Blumenbach sammelte die Schädel in allen Welttheilen und brachte die Ansicht hiervon in ein System. In welche Verlegenheit gerieth nun der Theologe? Wenn es nun nicht mehr einen Adam für alle Menschen, sondern einen Adam für die Kaukasier, einen andern für die Neger, einen dritten für die Amerikaner, einen vierten für die Malayen, einen fünften für die Mongolen u. s. w. gegeben hat; wo blieb nun die Dogmatik mit den einen Adam der Bibel, mit der Lehre vom Sündenfall und von der*

²⁰Vermischte Schriften. Zweiter Theil. Hamburg 1839. II. Was ist das Resultat der Wissenschaft in Bezug auf die Urwelt? p. 148 ff.

durch Adam auf alle Menschen gebrachten Schuld, wo nun mit der ganzen Lehre von der Erbsünde als Folge des Falles und einer von Adam aus durch Zeugung an alle Menschen gekommener Schwäche? Und ging diese verloren, wie stand nun die Nothwendigkeit der stellvertretenden Genugthuung Christi, des zweiten Adams, um die Schuld des ersten Adams aufzuheben, zu erweisen? Wo blieb nun der Grund der Verdammniss der Heiden, die nicht von Adam abstammen?“ — Tholuck is extremely indignant at this unreserved statement of Bretschneider's. “So lassen sich” — he exclaims — “die Diener der christlichen Kirche [37] im neunzehnten Jahrhundert nach Entstehung derselben vernehmen. Sieht man, nachdem eines Julianus, Porphyrius, Voltaires Stimme verklungen ist, die Pfleger des christlichen Heiligthums mit solchen Reden auftreten, wer muss nicht ausrufen: Herr! Bewahre deine Kirche vor ihren Freunden und Pflegern, mit ihren Feinden hat es keine Noth!”

As Tholuck now reviews the most important geologists from Descartes down to his own age and goes over paleontology with a fine-tooth comb, he naturally does not forget to cite a Cuvier, a Leopold von Buch, a Humboldt and others, but precisely thereby arrives at full assurance of his own theological result, that the whole thing signifies nothing. Theology is a true science; but geology, with its many hypotheses, is not really a science at all. “Der christliche Theologe kann in der That, so lange die geologische Wissenschaft keinen anderen Standpunkt als den gegenwärtigen einnimmt, in Bezug auf alle jene Hypothesen nur das stolze Wort gebrauchen, welches jene Königin von Schweden, Christine, sprach, da sie ihre Krone niederlegte: non mi bisogna e non mi basta — ich bedarf ihrer nicht und sie ist mir nicht genug”. When Tholuck, in order to explain creation, appeals to the Spirit of God that hovered over the waters, and for the rest refers to poetry²¹, the only remarkable thing about this is that he cannot himself notice that he has gone far beyond the limit of knowledge and of science.

As regards the paleontological, the Darwinian hypothesis has in recent decades so cleared things up in botany and zoology that it may perhaps be difficult to say of many able specialists on which side they really stand; only this much is clear, that they can hardly take their stand on the doctrine of a supernatural creation. E. Haeckel, one of the most eminent adherents of Darwinism, has by learning, acumen and systematizing talent shown the way to explain the origin of life from physical causes, conditions and laws, without any interference whatsoever of a pre-given teleology, and, by demonstrating the necessary transitional links, has traced the descent of the animals from the worm to man in one continuous series. His explanation of life we shall come back to; as for his systematics, zoologists in the future will no doubt find not only much to acknowledge [38]

²¹Op. cit. p. 172.

but also much to correct. A coherent, progressive development of the organic forms of nature may very well have its validity without science's therefore succeeding at once in demonstrating the particular transitional links; to invent them gives only subjective, not objective, satisfaction. In a treatment of the question "*Are birds descended from reptiles?*"²² Dr. Chr. Lütken has furnished an example of how the thorough, deliberate researcher conceives his tasks. After following the traces of the birds as far back as possible in the earth's developmental history, through the Cretaceous and Jurassic periods down to the Triassic, he ends with the result that the approximation of the birds to the reptiles is to be reckoned as little or nothing. "Perhaps," he says on p. 41, "we should seek the resemblance from the opposite side, from the *reptiles* over toward the birds? In that case it is to the past of the reptile class that we must turn, and we shall not long be in doubt as to what forms will especially claim our attention; it must be the flying *reptiles*!" But if we now consider *the long-snouted flying lizard* (*Pterodactylus longirostris*), it turns out after all that hope disappoints. "Only Cuvier's superior acumen and brilliant eye," it says on p. 45, "enabled him, from the imperfect drawings available to him, to work out that it was *a flying reptile*, a 'bat among the lizards,' but not a bat in the ordinary sense, not a mammal at all, any more than a bird." Since, on the whole, the flying lizards will not do, the attempt has been made with the giant lizards (the dinosaurs). "So close," says our author, following preceding explanations, on p. 99, "had the dinosaurs at long last come to the birds in the paleontologists' conception that it had to be regarded as [39] exceedingly doubtful whether one was able to distinguish their footprints from those of contemporaneous giant ostrich-birds! Then, at about the same time, some ten years ago, Prof. Cope in North America and Prof. Huxley in England came forward with discoveries and views based on them, according to which the dinosaurs and the ostriches were supposed to show such great approximations and agreements, notably in *the structure of the hind limbs*, that the dinosaurs had to be said, *at least in this respect*, to stand midway between birds and ordinary reptiles (crocodiles and present-day lizards)." It is notably with a view to *the transformation of the hind limbs* that the author warns against being finished too early with the doctrine of descent. "Perhaps," he says on p. 111, "victory has been prepared in this domain too, and may come before we expect it. But to send tidings of victory out into the world is not the same as really having won." It is with special regard to the scientific principle of cognition that we cite this. One does not go back to miraculous presuppositions because in science one works against overhasty theories. "We even readily grant," declares our author on p. 5, "that, were we to make the

²²Skildringer af Dyrelivet i Fortid og Nutid. Kjøbenhavn 1880.

choice between one of two—either to assume that all species are created by miracle (be it through a series of periodically recurring, collective renewals of the whole of organic nature, or by an infinity of isolated creations), *or* to assume that the species of the present have developed from those of the preceding period, and these in turn from those of the period before that, etc.—then the choice is not difficult for us. We naturally prefer the *possible* (more or less probable or improbable) to what is, scientifically speaking, absurd, even if we do not see that one has thereby got beyond all difficulties.”

Biology presents a difficulty of a peculiar kind. For not all physiologists have, as Haeckel has, the courage to deny every essential difference between the lifeless and the living, a difference that is supposed to be reducible to certain changes of molecules and physical forces. It can be expressly demonstrated that the forces in mechanics, chemical physics and chemistry act by virtue of properties in matter that correspond directly to the law of inertia and therefore betray no trace of life. That manifestations of life in the lowest, most imperfect organisms, monera, e.g., appear to be merely physical effects of physical forces is an easily explicable deception, which betrays itself when one goes back from a higher stage of life to lower ones. In Haeckel’s “*Generelle Morphologie der Organismen*” (p. 234, 1st part) it is said quite naively that the soul of the animal rests only on representations being awakened in the albumen molecules of the ganglion cells, i.e., when these molecules themselves begin to represent; the representation that is awakened by the *centripetal* fibers is *feeling*, therefore: the molecules feel; the representation that is awakened in the *centrifugal* fibers is *will*, therefore: the molecules will; the representation that is developed under very complicated interactions of centripetal and centrifugal fibers is *thought*. It is not, then, the ganglia and brain that merely furnish necessary conditions for thinking, but the albumen molecules of the ganglion cells are themselves thinking: the brain is the real subject of thinking. But however true it is that science can neither demonstrate whence organic life really comes nor make clear how the punctual interaction with matter takes place, it is nevertheless evident, and can be scientifically demonstrated, that a sum of the activity of elementary forces cannot by any change or transformation whatsoever be converted into vital activity, that every living organism must rest precisely on concrete individual unity, unity of difference, original unity of opposite functions, functions of matter and functions of selfhood²³. Even if, owing to the essential limitation of human knowledge, it is not possible to reach further, we can still, by reflecting on the general relation of subjective and objective that runs through the whole of nature, assure ourselves that the emergence and development of life rest on

²³Almindelig Videnskabslære. Kjøbenhavn 1880. p. 172 ff.

peculiar dispositions, which by no means break the scientific connection by requiring miracles.

“From a higher court to a lower bring not thy cause” — these words of an English physiologist, who will not make physiology immediately dependent on chemistry, apply especially to the relation between biology and the elementary sciences. Although physics and chemistry are such well-founded sciences that no one can doubt their validity, it is nevertheless undeniable that the foundation on which they rest, namely atoms and forces, can by no means be said to be either self-evident or sufficient in and of itself. A system of world-laws must necessarily be presupposed if a science is to be possible, and it cannot, as Kant would have it, be our own consciousness from which the world-laws proceed; but if we think all consciousness away, then there are no laws, any more than atoms and forces. Or might the objective perhaps be able to exist, not merely prior to our finite subjectivity, for that goes without saying, but prior to all subjectivity, hence before it was objectified? That is impossible. The laws cannot be without thoughts, since they have the universal determinations in themselves; but neither can they think themselves as forces in matter: here a mighty thinking self-unity must be presupposed, an eternal subjectivity, in which the existence of the objective world is grounded. Let us but admit that in the original relation between subjective and objective, between inner and outer, ideal and real, between the concepts of things and the existence of things, there is something impenetrable to our limited reason; the general fundamental relation itself nevertheless shows itself all the more clearly, the more we think about the reciprocal determination of things and laws, actuality and possibility, totality and disposition. If the solar system must presuppose a disposition in which the objective is originally determined by the subjective, if geological development must rest on a particular disposition preformed in the solar system, then the living organisms too must point back to dispositions that lie in the essence of subjectivity. This much stands fast, that what is subjective in the organisms cannot be derived from anything objective whatsoever, but points back to the eternal essence of subjectivity; but how the infinite subjectivity, which objectifies laws and things, informs the subjective dispositions into matter is and remains an impenetrable riddle: we stand at an insurmountable limit. [41]

If, now, it cannot be scientifically demonstrated how life comes forth in matter and acts; if, as regards its origin, an obscurity must necessarily remain here; with what right, then, can one demand that science should be able to give an exact account of what becomes of the soul when it leaves the body? Strict proofs have been given in the name of science that the soul is immortal, and in return equally strict proofs have been given

that the psychical itself must dissolve and vanish at the death of the body. Both attempts are equally invalid; in both cases science would overstep its proper limit. Matters stand correspondingly with the scientific treatment of the question of God's existence. It might indeed seem as though the subjectivity introduced in the *Videnskabslære*, truth's unity of knowledge and power, which furnishes the ideal-real presupposition for all objective actual nature, must be scientifically determinable as God himself, as the free author of the world, as absolute personality in original opposition to the impersonal; but that a characterization of the fundamental relation between subjective and objective, which runs through all existence, can by no means open to science any insight into God's supramundane essence, into God as God with absolute personality, has been expressly emphasized. "We cannot speak of spirit and nature as if spirit were outside nature, or nature outside spirit. The unity at issue here is a self-unity that belongs essentially to nature, and without which nature cannot possibly be. To that extent, then, self-knowledge is also knowledge of nature, self-comprehension comprehension of nature, self-power power of nature; but, be it noted, not from the standpoint of reality but from that of ideality. Ideality and reality are no doubt two sides of the same thing, but these two sides are also two totalities in one totality. The ideal totality is the spirit of nature; the real totality is actual nature. Whether one wishes to call this view theism, naturalism, dualism or monism is quite immaterial. What matters is exact determinations that can and must be taken up into the foundation of the science of spirit. The question [43] on which everything depends is thus this: how far can science reach in determining the fundamental relation between concept and reality, self-knowledge and knowledge of another, self-power and power in another, or, expressed otherwise, between freedom and necessity, spirit and nature"²⁴.

If, now, it is just as impossible for science to prove God's existence as his non-existence, just as impossible to prove the reality of such personal attributes as justice, love, mercy in the eternal subjectivity as to disprove it, just as impossible to prove as to disprove the supernatural, although a solution of such problems is of decisive significance for the personal self of man: what then follows from this? From this it certainly follows that besides scientific cognition, conditioned by necessity, there must be a religious cognition, conditioned by freedom. It goes here with science as it formerly went with religion. When, in the name of religion, the principle of faith had been made solely valid and ecclesiastical dogmatics the highest science, the tables turned: reason took power from faith, and the principle of cognition became scientific. But when one then, in the

²⁴Videnskabslære p. 227–228.

name of reason, would make the principle of knowledge the solely valid, all-embracing principle, the tables turn again, and we see that there must also be a principle of cognition in faith, that there must therefore be something that is an object of faith and cannot possibly become an object of knowledge.

IV.

The two principles, that of faith and that of knowledge, are, according to what we have now seen, not to be regarded as two sides of the selfsame thing, nor can they be [44] conceived as fragments of a single principle that has unfortunately cracked and broken to pieces. The two principles each have their own domain, the principle of faith the supernatural, the principle of knowledge the natural; and yet both, each in its own way, have the same domain, namely everything that can be sensed and represented, experienced and thought. The whole content of faith can, according to what we have said above, be made an object of knowledge, and conversely the whole content of knowledge can acquire significance for faith, without faith thereby being grounded on knowledge or knowledge on faith. It says (Ps. CIV, 14): “He”—God—“causes grass to spring up for the cattle and grain for the use of men”; the believer fixes his gaze on the natural in order to see in it a revelation of the supernatural; the knower sees in the supernatural a superfluous fancy, since both grass and grain can grow forth from a natural ground, on natural conditions. The difference in principle between faith and knowledge cannot, then, consist in the believer and the knower not understanding each other at all: but the understanding bends round into contradiction, in that they, each according to his principle, objectify in different ways: in faith the personal, and with it the subjective, has decisive preponderance; in knowledge, by contrast, what matters is the objective, the impersonal.

This shows itself clearly in the conception of laws and miracles. When, on account of the immediacy with which faith in revelation sets miracles against natural events in its language, it has been claimed that such a faith in miracles must necessarily presuppose that the laws are broken, this is, as far as the principle is concerned, entirely false; the truth is that faith refers both the laws of nature and the miracles to God’s almighty will. The theological-scientific, i.e. unscientific, conception of God’s omnipotence has certainly led to absurd consequences²⁵; but it is, after all, not about theology, it is about [45]

²⁵Malebranche. *De la recherche de la vérité* p. 390. *Dieu a créé le monde . . . et produit ainsi tous les effets, que nous voyons arriver, parce qu’ il a voulu aussi certaines loix, selon lesquelles les mouvemens se communiquent à la rencontre des corps: et parce que ces loix sont efficaces, elles agissent et les corps ne peuvent agir.* Om Theologiens Naturbegreb. Ved Reformationsfesten 1855.

religion that we are speaking here. If science now follows its principle consistently, it must undeniably keep strictly to unchangeable laws; but since these laws belong at once to knowledge and to power, and since the unity of power with knowledge may in truth presuppose will, it is impossible for science to decide whether the necessity of the laws is not perhaps determined in the last instance by divine freedom, and so whether the apparent interruption of the laws of nature by the miracles is not precisely the true expression of the origin of those laws. Science has, according to its principle and the objectification determined by it, reason to reject all miracles without exception, but, be it noted, on the condition that it acknowledges another principle, insofar as it acknowledges a possibility that it cannot itself see through. Science is not atheistic insofar as it declares outright that it does not know the God of religion, for this God is no scientific quantity; science is not unbelieving because it will have nothing to do with miracles, for miracles are not objects of knowledge. When science subjects the accounts of creation and paradise to a sharp critique, it merely gives an account of the limit of its cognition, but does not thereby prove that creation and paradise have no real significance.

If faith, then, has its principle just as well as knowledge, it follows, of course, that there must be thoughts of faith just as well as thoughts of knowledge, grounds of faith just as well as grounds of knowledge, and naturally also a critique of faith just as well as a critique of knowledge. The critique of faith must then secure the religious conception of the content of revelation, by not only repelling the unwarranted interference of knowledge, but also taking care, in determining the relation between miracle and law of nature, not to come into contradiction with itself. That faith too must have its critique shows itself, then, especially in its relation to the miracles. If anyone will claim that a believer who can accept one single miracle must be able to accept all, this must no doubt be granted, insofar as faith is opposed to knowledge; but it by no means follows from this either that all possible miracle stories must stand on an equal footing in the eyes of faith, or that the miracles in the New Testament are equally decisive for the life of faith to the same extent; only the miracle of creation and the miracles of incarnation and inspiration are fundamental for the critique of faith. [46]

The question of miracles and laws of nature is most intimately connected with the question of rational reality and spiritual reality, and this in turn with the question of the objective and its objectification. Why paradise and the fall cannot possibly assert real objectivity for themselves in science is obvious; why paradise and the fall must necessarily assert real objectivity for themselves in faith is likewise obvious. By assigning

to faith and to knowledge each its own principle of cognition, we seem, then, to make the opposition so strong that it must necessarily burst the unity of human consciousness; the believer cannot be a knower, the knower not a believer; and so the whole ends in an intolerable dualism. "For the subject standing outside," says Strauss²⁶, "revelation must prove by external objective signs that it is revelation; it must document its origin from the absolute intelligence by showing, in the domain that the finite spirit can check, how it surpasses the latter, which happens through *prophecies*; it must prove its origin from the absolute power by dominion over the power of nature, through *wonders*. In order to be carried down to posterity, revelation must be preserved in *holy scriptures*, but these must, so that one can be sure that revelation is kept undistorted in them, be inspired by the author of revelation. Yet this whole apparatus for making revelation secure and accessible to us still lies throughout on the objective side; there is still lacking the most important thing, the subject's appropriation of the revealed content. The subject appropriates revelation through the *interpretation of Scripture*, but how is it to assure itself that the alleged revelation is really divine? Through the wonders and prophecies that accompanied it when it took place. Good, but how will one be able to know that [47] these are real wonders and prophecies? From the testimony of Scripture. But how does one know that this is true? From its being inspired by the infallible God. But that Scripture is inspired by God, how does one know that? From the *inner testimony of the Holy Spirit*, which, when we read Scripture, recognizes in it its own work. Good, but what is now to convince us that this testimony in us really comes from the Holy Spirit, and not from our own spirit, or even from a seducing spirit outside us?—Here the thread of the orthodox system snaps... He who does not have the spirit within him has it outside him; he who cannot find the determining principle in himself seeks it in a revelation; he who is not yet ripe for the faith of reason remains with faith in revelation." Relying on what he calls the faith of reason, Strauss points to a chasm between two classes of human society, the knowers and the people, the non-philosophizing in the higher as well as in the lower ranks, a chasm that will perhaps never be filled. "So let," he says, "the believer then let the knower, just as the latter the former, go his way in peace; we let them keep their faith, so they must also let us keep our philosophy; and if the overly pious should succeed in excluding us from their church, we would count it a gain; enough false attempts at union have now been made; only a sharpening of the oppositions can lead further."

That the Straussian separation between believers and knowers is thoroughly false can

²⁶Cf. "Om Holbergs Kirkehistorie og Theologi" by the present author. Copenhagen 1867. p. 71 ff.

be seen from what we have said above. Reason, if we keep to the principle, has neither any religion nor a substitute for religion to offer us; every religious object, even an Egyptian Apis, presupposes a believing subjectivity and, in all its naturalness, points to the supernatural. If this supernatural has nothing higher, nothing subjective or personal, in it, it must consistently consume man's personal self, and faith then shows itself active from the negative side. Thoroughgoing nihilism, which dissolves all faith, dissolves all knowledge too. This is seen clearly from "The Philosophy of the Unconscious"²⁷. Right from Schelling's first youthful appearance with the intellectual intuition of the absolute [48] down to the most recent time, speculative philosophy, in ambiguous understanding with natural science, has labored to make the absolute being clear to itself. It has, however, been difficult for the intelligent, co-philosophizing public to keep up and to find out how matters really stood with this absolute. Now it was presented as a logically omniscient deity: God in the Logic before he created the world; now again as an unopened, obscure principle, the indwelling ground and cause of all existence. Now at last the ambiguity has been removed; the countenance of the god of truth is seen completely unveiled. The riddle of the world is that an unconscious willing has from the beginning driven a likewise unconscious representation from non-being into being, for, it says on p. 607, "in itself representation had no drive and no interest to pass from non-being over into being; consequently, before the entry of will no representing was actual; consequently, before the coming-to-be of the world there was neither willing nor representing, i.e. '*gar Nichts*'. As long as willing lasts, so long will the process and its appearance in consciousness, the world, last; when, therefore, there is one day to be no world any more, then there may no longer be any willing or any representation either, since unconscious representation only ever becomes actual insofar as the interest of will demands it, i.e. there will again be '*gar Nichts*'." With this, then, the following description of the deity also agrees (p. 606): "The All-One Unconscious is omniscient and all-wise, and consequently cannot become wiser than it already is; it has, as Aristotle too says, no memory, so it can learn nothing from the experiences it otherwise had in the world. Consequently, when the world has once ceased to be, it has remained exactly the same as it was before the creation of the world; as blessed as it formerly was, it is now again, neither more nor less; the world process can in no way help it to greater blessedness than it formerly had." If the deity is blessed in nothing, it follows of itself that the soul too must become blessed in nothing. The hope of an individual continuance of the soul after death is declared outright to be an illusion. "With that the main nerve of the Christian promises is cut, for at bottom [49]

²⁷Philosophie des Unbewussten. Versuch einer Weltanschauung von Ev. Hartmann, Dr. phil. Berlin 1869.

man cares only about his own dear I; what good to me is the greatest future blessedness if I cannot perceive and enjoy it!"²⁸

In nihilism not only faith but knowledge too perishes. That out of nothing itself, pure nothing, a representing and willing should have formed themselves, and by their union a real world, which will in turn dissolve itself into the infinite nothing, is surely as meaningless as possible. A real existence, an original unity-in-opposition of subjective and objective, and, as far as man is concerned, an essential difference between impersonal objectifying in knowledge and personal objectification in faith, must necessarily be presupposed. We shall try to illustrate this by some examples. That the biblical account of the creation of the world does not agree with the scientific conception of the world of things contains, when we look more closely, no contradiction. When one and the same object is objectified by two persons under equal conditions with the same sense, e.g. sight, and yet presents itself differently, to the one as blue, to the other as gray, there must naturally be a fault in the organ of sight either in the one or in the other, if not in both; but when the one can judge only by sight, the other by contrast by his own feeling, one cannot demand full agreement, even if the object in and for itself is assumed to be the same. Science, which dwells on natural elements, atoms, primal nebula, physical causes, conditions and laws, does not reach spirit; its impersonal objectification, however rational it may be, must stop at the externally real. In religion, by contrast, objectification is originally determined by the peculiar co-operation of spirit. The earth, the sun, the moon are indeed conceived as they immediately show themselves to sense and understanding, but what is decisive lies in the assurance that the spirit of faith awakens about their origin and their relation to the subjective, the personal. It must be expressly emphasized that the scientific presentation of the universe cannot possibly come into conflict with the religious one, unless science goes beyond its limit, abolishes the imagination of revelation, and itself undertakes to decide how matters stand in principle with creator and creature. Nor can the religious conception of a creation in six days come into conflict with the doctrine of a successive development, unless religion will give up its limitation in principle, set itself in the high seat of science, and show clearly how millions of years shrink to six days. [50]

"But," one objects, "if a settlement between religion and science is to be grounded on so principled a difference in the mode of objectification that science gives real objectivity, freed from all extraneous interferences, as it is, while religion gets its peculiar world through an objectification that transforms reality by mixing in the personal, then the

²⁸For Ide og Virkelighed. Vol. 1875. Hvorledes man danner sig en Verdensanskuelse. p. 12–14.

whole thing is confused. What, pray, becomes of this personal when we speak plainly? The mythical! If expressions such as personal objectivity, spiritual reality, reality of revelation are nothing other than paraphrases of what we already know under the name of the mythical, then nothing at all is gained hereby toward a real illumination of the self-validity of religion over against science.” We shall test this objection by casting a glance at paradise. That paradise, in every form, must in science be an illusory reality, a delusion of the imagination, a myth, cannot, according to what we have said above, be contradicted; but we have, after all, granted faith its principle, so that it should not stand under the tutelage of knowledge, but have the right to assert its own view of the world and to apply its own critique. Let us then, with the principle of faith before our eyes, consider paradise from the standpoint of revelation, of myth and of poetry. Revelation begins with a setting in which the deity, in a sensuous-supersensuous presence, lives together with man; this paradisaal reality is spiritual reality. The immediate fusion of natural and supernatural, however, already belongs to the past when paradise becomes an object of faith. Since the past cannot be seen immediately but must be viewed in the [51] reflecting mirror of the imagination, it becomes uncertain whether faith can find the given signs, from the divine as well as from the human side, so satisfying that it must hold fast in the paradisaal phenomena to essential features of a true revelation, or whether, as reflection is set in motion, an uncertainty sets in about what is divine and what is human, how much is supernatural, how much is natural. In the latter case revelation is transformed into myth. The mythical has many changing shapes, and furnishes a foundation for poetry and art. The paradise with which Ovid begins his *Metamorphoses* is evidently merely poetic; the paradise of the Persian religion is mythical; but why is the paradise of the Hebrews and the Christians neither merely poetic nor mythical, but a real revelation? That must be decided in principle in faith, not in knowledge. According to the principle of knowledge all paradises are mythical, the Mosaic-Christian just as well as the Persian and the Muhammadan. The paradisaal reality of faith is spiritual reality; the faith that in the deepest sense recognizes the personal relation between God and man must therefore, in the name of revelation, recognize the true, spiritually real paradise.

If we are to examine in particular the activity of Christ and of the devil, the same principle applies, the principle of faith. That there really lived in Palestine a man by the name of Jesus who said that he was the Christ, the only-begotten Son of God, science will not deny; Jesus of Nazareth is really a historical personality, and as such has a claim to historical faith. But historical faith (*fides historica*) is different in principle from religious faith (*fides religiosa*); Jesus as God’s Son become man, Jesus as the virgin-born, as the

wonder-worker, as the risen and ascended one, in short: Jesus as the Christ is the object not of merely historical but of religious faith. What holds of Christ holds also of the devil. The devil himself, it is true, is not yet incarnate—the Antichrist, after all, has not yet come—yet it is seen from what we have said above that the scientific critique that begins by dissolving the personality of the devil must consistently end by dissolving the personality of Christ; from which, then, the converse also follows, that the faith that in principle will hold fast to the personal Christ must also acknowledge the personal devil. [52]

If one will now conclude from this that, since faith and knowledge are so diametrically opposed, the believer cannot possibly be a knower, and the knower not a believer, then the conclusion is utterly false. If the objects of faith are so different in principle from the objects of knowledge that one can be a believer without being a knower, because the religious objects are personal, the scientific ones by contrast impersonal, then it also follows from this that the believer can be a knower, and the knower a believer, without coming into contradiction with himself. An astronomer who would at once embrace both the Ptolemaic and the Copernican world system certainly comes into contradiction with himself, for both systems are results of the same kind of objectification: if the one is true, the other must necessarily be untrue. He, on the other hand, who in his capacity as astronomer embraces the Copernican system, but in his capacity as believer the Mosaic account, does not come into contradiction with himself; for in aiming through the natural at the supernatural and objectifying personally in imagination, he cannot possibly objectify scientifically. When one person holds fast in faith that man was created on the sixth day, while another believes that he was created only six million years after the first formation of the earth, they are in real contradiction with each other, for they move within the same sphere; but when a believer asserts that man is created in the image of God, while a zoologist asserts that man has developed from the same basic form as the ape, then there is no contradiction in this; for they are speaking of utterly different things. “That God Jehovah formed man, dust of the earth, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life” (Gen. II, 7) concerns not the natural development but solely the origin from God, which can be made intuitable only in personal objectification; man’s development from a natural basic form decides nothing about creation. If, on the other hand, the believer will not be content to emphasize the divine act of creation, of which the inbreathing of the breath of life is a significant symbol, but ventures to determine the course of development, he violates his principle and is thereby already in the wrong. If, conversely, the scientific researcher, who according to the principle of knowledge objectifies to himself the stepwise development of nature, will deny the [53]

moment of creation lying in the original disposition, which he does not know at all, he oversteps his limit and violates his principle. Here there is on both sides a contentious insistence on being right which harms religion and science in equal measure.

Should one perhaps object that it is only in certain special cases that one can appeal to a mode of objectification different in principle, and to a correspondingly different kind of reality, in order to remove the conflict between faith and knowledge, but that this way out is far from sufficing in the most difficult, most important cases, then let us once more cast a glance at Christ's resurrection and ascension. If it is really the man Jesus, and not a general idea of Christ or a merely spiritual Christ, who has risen from the dead and ascended into heaven, then the object of faith cannot possibly be detached from the object of knowledge without the whole reality having to become mythical. He who rises from the grave and shows himself to the disciples is, after all, the crucified one, he whom all, unbelievers and believers alike, could see with sensuous eyes and grasp with sensuous hands, and so objectify to themselves both in the manner of knowledge and in that of faith; but after the resurrection his form is as if wholly transformed, real and yet super-real; Mary Magdalene cannot recognize him (John XX. 15–17), nor can the two who went to Emmaus (Luke XXIV); he goes through closed doors, and the disciples think they see a spirit; but Thomas, who wants tangible certainty, gets it and believes (John XX; 19–31). Of a scientific presentation of such events there can be no question here at all. The objectivity is, like religion itself, the revealing of what is incomprehensible in personality, spiritual reality in contemplable form, an object of faith, not of knowledge.

That faith and knowledge, each with its principle, do not stand in contradiction with each other must surely be clear from the foregoing; but faith and knowledge are, after all, heterogeneous cognitions: the question then becomes how they can be united in the unity of human consciousness. To this the following must be answered: science, having become fully conscious of its principle, its right, its freedom, cannot see in religion as divine revelation any enemy that will intervene disruptively in its investigations; even if scientific cognition cannot fathom personality itself, there must nonetheless be reason in all personal thinking. For its part, religion cannot then stand hostile toward science either; even if, for personal reasons, it refers the laws of existence to God's will and lets the natural be subordinate to the supernatural, this subordination cannot possibly mean any breach of the laws. When it is said that Christ was under the law in order to fulfill the law, this holds not of the Mosaic law alone but of the law of the world, the law of nature. Although religion, with its principle of personality, is not dependent on science, it is not therefore excluded from science. The principle of religion is also the principle of

morality; but the principle of morality works in society on such natural conditions that in its universal validity it must satisfy the demands of reason, and for that reason it has been confused with the principle of reason itself.

Religion too, or rather the doctrine of religion, has need of scientific illumination, only this illumination must not give itself the appearance of scientific grounding. "The philosophy of religion does not stop at general determinations of the limits of faith and knowledge; it cannot possibly let religion develop its content without letting a whole system of concepts of faith come to development. But the religious content of faith is, according to the principle, a suprascientific content; here, then, the contradiction arises that a suprascientific content is taken up into science. If the form of science were now really confused with the true, original form of the content and introduced and held fast in place of it, the contradiction would certainly be insoluble. But this is by no means the case. Scientific reflection has precisely the flexibility that it brings the form [55] of knowledge to reflect another and opposite form. For just as the clear day can bring the eye to forget the gleam of light and look at the objects, so too reflection can bring thought, in knowledge, to look at faith and forget knowledge. The philosophy of religion is so far from forcing an alien form on the religious content that its development of form consists, on the contrary, in freeing that content from admixtures of immediately individual representations, images, feelings, expressions of will, etc., with which it is always grown together in the life of faith itself. Insofar as reflection, as regards the form as well as the content, cancels knowledge through knowledge, in that it aims to clarify not a scientific but a suprascientific truth, the relation between truth and science is essentially reversed, and the philosophy of religion is in this respect to be characterized as an inverted science."²⁹

You shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.

²⁹Religionsphil. p. 8–11.